

EGG-LAYING MAMMALS

There are just five species in this group of mammals, which are known as monotremes. All of them have a specialized snout and lay eggs.

The monotremes, which are the duck-billed platypus and the long-nosed and short-nosed echidnas, form the order Monotremata. They are found in various habitats in New Guinea, Australia, and Tasmania.

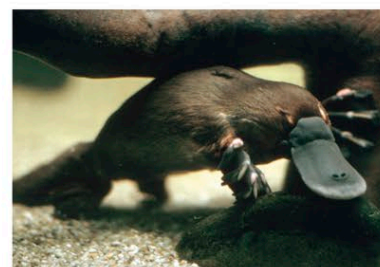
Platypuses and echidnas lay soft-shelled eggs that hatch after around ten days' incubation. The young feed on milk secreted from the female's mammary glands; monotremes have no teats. Infant echidnas live in their mother's pouch until their spines appear and then, like young platypuses, stay in a burrow for several months.

Monotremes have a specialized snout for finding and eating prey. The platypus, which is partly aquatic, has a flattened, duck-like bill covered with sensory receptors that allow the animal to locate invertebrates under water, even in murky conditions. The long, cylindrical snout and long tongue of the land-dwelling echidnas are ideal for probing the nests of ants and termites, and for catching worms. Neither the platypus nor the echidnas have teeth; instead they have grinding surfaces or horny spines on their tongue.

WHAT'S IN A NAME

The word "monotreme" means "single hole" and makes reference to the cloaca, a single posterior body opening into which the digestive, urinary, and reproductive tracts empty.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	MAMMALIA
ORDER	MONOTREMATA
FAMILIES	2
SPECIES	5



The large, webbed forefeet of the duck-billed platypus provide propulsion. The hind feet and tail are used to steer.

DUCK-BILLED PLATYPUS

The sole member of the family Ornithorhynchidae, the duck-billed platypus is well adapted to a semi-aquatic lifestyle. It has a streamlined body, waterproof fur, webbed feet, and a flattened tail. Males have a venomous horny spur on each hind foot.



40–63 cm
16–25 in

DUCK-BILLED PLATYPUS

Ornithorhynchus anatinus

Found in rivers and streams in E. Australia and Tasmania, this rare species uses its soft bill, which is covered in electroreceptors, to hunt for invertebrates.

ECHIDNAS

The family Tachyglossidae is made up of the long- and short-beaked echidnas. Their rounded body is covered with fur and spines, and the long snout is ideal for seeking out insects, ants, and worms.

30–45 cm
12–18 in

SHORT-BEAKED ECHIDNA

Tachyglossus aculeatus

Widespread in Australia, Tasmania, and New Guinea, the short-beaked echidna lays a single egg into a pouch on its abdomen.



48–63 cm
19–25 in

EASTERN LONG-BEAKED ECHIDNA

Zaglossus bartoni

The largest of the monotremes, this species lives in the forested highlands of E. New Guinea.

